We Both Go Down Together

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55590409.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Nightmares, Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence

Language:
English

Series:
Part 5 of Claim Your Kingdom

Stats:
Published: 2024-04-30 Words: 1,796 Chapters: 1/1

We Both Go Down Together

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55590409.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Nightmares, Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence

Language:
English

Series:
Part 5 of Claim Your Kingdom

Stats:
Published: 2024-04-30 Words: 1,796 Chapters: 1/1

We Both Go Down Together

by Kurt_Angles_Tailbone

Summary

"…to touch you, okay? Could you let go of the sink for me?" Glimmer's voice was a gentle whisper, infinitely calm and infinitely measured as she tried to walk him through his return to the surface.

"You're in Brightmoon. You're safe."

Bow struggles to deal with the mental scars of the ongoing war against the Horde. Glimmer is there to help him.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"Rifles! Get me a firing line!"

"Incoming! Sorcerers, employ shields! Shields, I say!"

Dirt rained down on Bow's head, a cloud of dust wafting in his face and making his eyes water. Still, Glimmer was relying on him, so he plunged into the churning mass of bodies, half-blind and wretchedly tired.

"What's the situation, captain!"

The woman drew up with a perfunctory salute, dried blood coating the side of her face. "Reinforcements are still an hour out, Tech-Master Bow, sir! We're getting royally arse-fucked here, excuse my Salinean." She sighed, attention briefly caught by a distant explosion. "We could really use some relief."

"INCOMING!"

Another blast shook Bow to his bones and set his ears ringing. The second one harshly threw him down against the dirt. Instinctively, he moved to drag the captain down with him and shield her from the barrage.

"Princess Spinnerella will be here soon!" Bow promised, once he managed to get to his feet and open his eyes again. "We just have to hold out…"

He paused. He stared down at the woman he was holding.

Or what was left of her.

Bow's eyes shot open. Instantly, the ceiling began to spin, teetering off the axis of his own equilibrium. Dark blotches welled at the edge of his vision, hurting his eyes. Three thoughts shot through his brain, then.

I am in Brightmoon.

I can't breathe.

And, treacherously, despite her many assurances that he should wake her up whenever this happened…

Don't wake up Glimmer.

His nightly terrors had only brought Glimmer to his bedchamber door a few times, but, caught up in the chaos of a rude awakening, those few times felt like they were a few times too many to Bow. Glimmer was already inundated by leading the Rebellion, by leading the fight for freedom against the Horde. Lying there, frozen solid and trying to will himself to breathe, Bow could only think about how unfair it would be to Glimmer for her to have to deal with his issues, too.

But it was no use. If he didn't take a breath, he would surely die. Hounded by that thought, Bow threw his whole body into a desperate gasp that somehow emerged as little more than a teeny tiny wheezing breath. Yet it was enough. His next breaths came quicker, marginally steadier, and his head cleared.

Experience taught him this wasn't the last of it. He sat upright, wiped his sweat-soaked face down on the sweat-soaked sleeve of his pyjamas and stumbled out of bed. Once, he hadn't even made it as far as the bathroom, collapsing down by the waterfall and using his cupped hands to splash his face and wet his throat.

He made it this time, though. Semantics meant he leaned rather than crashed against the sink, by which time his heart was pounding in his temples and his thoughts were nothing but a veritable whirlwind of screams, just barely keeping his head together. It was instinct and habit that had him turn the tap on, for every thread of thought ended in a warbling mess of noise that hurt in a way physical pain never could.

Bow tried to focus on the stream of water, on the sound of it. He pawed around the basin, found the plug and filled the drain. He watched the basin fill up. He watched his reflection in the mirror.

The noise ultimately died down. Maybe it was the running tap, maybe he just got off lucky—insofar as you could call it lucky. The water kept coming. The basin filled up. He didn't register the water dribbling past where he was gripping the sides of the sink, didn't register it spilling over his bare feet.

A door opened and shut outside. Bow tensed, waited, but the footsteps went the opposite direction. He sucked in a sharp intake of air and hit the faucet blindly, shutting it off. He was standing in a large pool of water. Perhaps if the sun was out, he could reckon a clear train of thought. *It's fine. We all have our issues. It's no trouble.*

But with the night came dark thoughts, and the clarity of the day before was little more than a distant fantasy. Bow looked at the wet mess, the drenched towels and the soaked toiletries and felt himself dragged down, stuck in an endless cycle of self-disparagement.

Morbid impulse had him hound after the face of the captain he saw in his dream. She had been real, of that much he was sure. It was often enough that he saw faces he didn't recognise, that he envisioned scenarios that weren't real. Fears that had taken root early on in the war against the Horde—*we're out of time, artillery's incoming, we're surrounded, we're not getting reinforcements, we're about to die.*

A young Satyr girl yanking on his wrist, desperately crying for him to see to her mother. Bow didn't follow her wild gesticulating. It wasn't a pretty sight that awaited him under the rubble, and it wasn't one that instilled any hope.

"Please!" she kept screaming. "Please! Mum! My mum! Please! Help her, PLEASE!"

Her voice was raw from screaming. Her mother kept making that incoherent noise that death made. Hellish. Inhuman. Awful. Just awful.

He wasn't proud of it. He sank down to his knees, one arm pressed against his ears while he kept the head of the girl down with the other. It wasn't the first time a battle had him freeze up. It wouldn't be the last.

"Bow?"

He took another breath. It sounded wet and nasal on his own ears. He was crying. His eyes were swimming when he tried to open them. There were clammy streaks on his cheeks, and all of it stung something fierce.

Glimmer was here. Bow cursed himself, silently. All that effort, and he still managed to wake her up.

She was talking to him, but the sound came up muted as if underwater, drowned out by the ringing echoes in his ears. Bow swallowed, tried to banish the phantom images of the girl's mother, tried to dislodge his own fingers.

"…to touch you, okay? Could you let go of the sink for me?" Glimmer's voice was a gentle whisper, infinitely calm and infinitely measured as she tried to walk him through his return to the surface. "You're in Brightmoon. You're safe."

Bow swallowed again, peeling his fingers off the sink with the selfsame sensation of bending back metal. When he finally managed it, the world didn't fall out from under him as his subconscious led him to believe. The snorted breath that came out next was hoarse, raggedy and far the opposite of grounding. He was a mess.

"Bow? How are you feeling?" A pause, as Bow tried to muster the words. "Do you want to go back to your bed?"

Nodding was easy. Glimmer was at his side directly after, taking him by his elbows and tenderly forcing him to turn away from the sight of his own harried self in the mirror.

The slow shuffle back to his bed was terrible. Cold, wet feet, head bursting with warmth and sweat, and yet it felt as though a simple breeze could knock him off his feet.

Glimmer carefully guided him down onto the side of the bed, her hands moving to intertwine with his and squeezing once. He squeezed hers back, and then clenched—with cognisance and wakefulness came their discussed routine, and as bad as he felt about waking Glimmer up, he knew she *wanted* him to rely on her, as much as he wanted her to rely on him.

After all, *together* is what they always told each other.

"How are you feeling, Bow?" Glimmer asked quietly, running her thumb over his knuckles.

"Better," he managed, swallowing a shivering breath that sounded suspiciously like a sob.

Bow was the first guy to tell you that needing a shoulder to lean or cry on was okay, that a helping hand was always welcome, extended and accepted both. Still, that didn't stop him from uttering a wet apology.

"I didn't mean to wake you."

"That's okay," Glimmer said immediately. Calm, patient, unbudgingly firm. "I… was already awake."

"Oh." Bow subconsciously drew himself up, preparing to immerse himself into the role of that shoulder to lean on. "Do you want to talk about it?"

"It's fine. I was just thinking about yesterday's meeting." Glimmer squeezed his hand again. "What about you?"

A silence, as Bow both worked to steady his breathing and tread the line between drudging up the details of his episode and trying his utmost to forget them.

Glimmer leaned against his shoulder, voice soft. “It sounded bad.”

“I… still don’t feel great,” Bow finally said in a measured voice, and then quickly added, “but I don’t think it’s happening again. I think I’m alright.”

Glimmer hummed. “That’s good. I’m glad to hear that.”

Bow pushed all the air out of his lungs, taking the leap. “It was the, uh, battle at Windcreek again.”

Glimmer’s look was knowing, caught from the corner of his eyes. “That was years ago, Bow. You saved a lot of people that day.”

“I know.”

“And you’re not there anymore. You’re in Brightmoon. And you’re safe.”

“I know.” He did. He just really needed to hear the words to drive them home.

This time the silence was easier to endure, and a lot more comforting. The shared, mutual quiet between Glimmer and him was precious to him, as much as her friendship and her presence.

“I’d best… clean up and sleep.”

Glimmer nodded. “Do you want me to fetch you a towel?”

“No.” The answer came out instantly, and maybe he held onto Glimmer a little tighter. She didn’t show any sign of noticing, other than that she held him tighter too.

“That’s okay. I’ll just stay with you.”

Another silence, riding out the tremors in his chest. Sometimes they crept up on him in the aftermath, obscure but no less impactful for it.

“Can I stay with you tonight?”

Bow was tremendously grateful that Glimmer asked. Not that he had any trouble asking himself. Words just weren't very forthcoming, right this second.

"Yeah. I… I think that'd be good."

He didn't clean up, in the end. Glimmer guided him down to a prone position, adjusting into the pillows, and then covered the both of them with the blanket.

Adora's departure had left something of a void in Brightmoon, strangely poignant despite her time here having only lasted a few years. But if there was one thing Bow was thankful for, it was that her absence had brought him and Glimmer closer together.

Because Glimmer needed him, and the stars knew he needed Glimmer.

End Notes

Work title is from We Both Go Down Together by The Decemberists.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!